

born after a high number of young men migrated to Japan in search of work.

Uttarakhand's mountains cover nearly 86 per cent of its land, and about 70 per cent of its people, ostensibly, still live in rural areas. For decades now, these hills have watched people leave—first for nearby towns, then for cities across India. The result: a landscape dotted with silent villages and empty homes.

## LONG SHADOW OF MIGRATION

Migration out of Uttarakhand's hills is not a new phenomenon. It began during the British era, when regular recruitment to the Garhwal and Kumaon regiments and occasional mass labour movements to the plains first linked the region to the wider world. British recruitment brought steady incomes and exposure to urban life, normalising migration as a livelihood strategy. The trickle became a flood in the late 20th century as farming became unviable. Earlier waves were mostly male-driven and often seasonal. Now, entire families move out, showing a shift that is reflected in the local economies that depend on remittances rather than farming or local enterprise.

Of the families left, most tell a familiar story, of men stuck in faraway places, women holding the household together, and children growing up without their fathers. In Sarpoli village, 60 out of its 111 families have left. mostly to Dehradun, Delhi or Mumbai, and a few overseas. Sajjan still tills his small patch of land and takes up the odd repair jobs that come his way. "If there is no work, there is nothing," he shrugs. A few kilometres from Sarpoli, in Mathkuri Sain Hindaw village, locals say that out of nearly 2,500 residents, over 1,500 now live elsewhere, including some as far afield as Germany, Japan and Qatar. The money sent home has built new houses, but hollowed out families from within.

Sajjan Singh, a daily-wage worker in Sarpoli, says the conditions make it almost impossible to return. It took two years of effort to get a motorable road built here. Until then, residents had to walk four kilometres to reach the nearest bus stop. Wild animals add another layer of hardship. "We can't step out after dark," Singh says. The nearest government hospital is 150 km away in New Tehri; for private healthcare, people have to travel 40 km to Ghansali. "I know 20 families who would come back if there were better amenities," says Singh.

## THE MISSING ECONOMY

The state government acknowledges that outmigration is one of its biggest challenges. According to the Uttarakhand Rural Development and Migration Prevention Commission, between 2011 and 2022, of the total population of 11.6 million, over 690,000 people have left their homes 'temporarily'; another 147,000 moved out permanently (see *Why they left*). In the same period, 758 villages (of the total 16,800) have turned into what officials call "ghost villages"—with next to nobody living there.

Altogether, it is estimated that over 10 per cent of the 8.1 million rural population has moved out. The problem is particularly severe in development blocks along the state's international borders with China and Nepal, where



**"We are doing what the government should be doing. Just asking people to return and do farming is not enough. There is no focus on skill development. On paper, there are many schemes, the ground reality is very different"**

**— DEEPAK NAUTIYAL,** *Corporate manager-turned-farmer*